

Search

Search Engine Optimization (SEO)

What it is: Improving a website's visibility in unpaid (organic) search results through on-page work (content, keywords, meta tags), technical fixes (site speed, mobile-friendliness, crawlability), and off-page authority building (backlinks, domain trust).

Examples: Optimizing a blog post to rank for "best running shoes 2026"; fixing slow page-load times; earning backlinks from reputable industry sites.

Scope of growth: One of the most consistently in-demand marketing skills — nearly every business with a website needs it. Growth paths lead into technical SEO, international SEO, and now increasingly overlap with GEO (below).

Money: Freelancers: \$30–150/hour (Rs. 2,500–12,000/hr in India). In-house SEO roles: \$50k–120k/year in the US, Rs. 4–15 LPA in India. Agencies charge \$500–10,000+/month in retainers.

Generative Engine Optimization (GEO) (NEW)

What it is: A new discipline focused on getting a brand cited, quoted, or recommended by AI answer engines (ChatGPT, Google AI Overviews/AI Mode, Perplexity, Copilot) rather than just ranking on a results page. It extends SEO with citable facts, clear structure, entity/brand signals, and structured data that LLMs can parse and trust.

Examples: Writing answer-first content that directly answers a question in the first few lines; adding schema markup so AI systems can extract facts accurately; tracking how often a brand gets cited in AI responses using an "AI visibility" tool.

Scope of growth: Extremely high-growth and still early — as more discovery shifts from search results to AI chat answers, GEO is quickly becoming a required skill alongside SEO. Very few true specialists exist yet, so early movers have a real edge.

Money: Rates are still forming, but GEO consultants are already commanding \$75–250/hour, often at a premium over standard SEO. Many agencies now bundle it into SEO retainers at a markup rather than selling it standalone.

Search Engine Marketing (SEM)

What it is: Paid search advertising — buying placement at the top of search results (mainly via Google Ads or Bing Ads) on a cost-per-click basis for specific keywords.

Examples: Bidding on "emergency plumber near me" to appear above organic listings; running Google Shopping ads for an online store's products.

Scope of growth: Steady, strong demand since almost every online business eventually runs paid search. Specialists who can manage large budgets efficiently are highly valued.

Money: Freelancers: \$40–100+/hour. Agencies typically charge 10–20% of ad spend or flat retainers of \$1,000–5,000+/month. In-house SEM managers: \$55k–110k/year in the US.

Local SEO

What it is: Optimizing a business's online presence to rank in local searches and map results — e.g., "coffee shop near me." Covers Google Business Profile optimization, local citations, reviews, and localized content.

Examples: Optimizing a dentist's Google Business Profile with photos, hours, and review responses; building local directory listings for a restaurant chain.

Scope of growth: High demand from small, local businesses (clinics, salons, contractors, restaurants); a good specialization for new freelancers since it's less competitive than broad SEO.